



Ethical Coherence Under Constraint in the PortusSophia™ Series

Diagnostic discipline note (standalone; non-prescriptive)

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Adjacency (non-derivative / non-prerequisite): This note is structurally adjacent to other PortusSophia™ research artifacts; it may be cited without establishing a prerequisite relationship.

Posture: Diagnostic; non-prescriptive; standalone.

Abstract

Ethical discourse is often grounded in human intention, moral reasoning, or normative prescription. This paper offers a descriptive alternative: ethics is examined as a pre-anthropological relational condition concerned with how cost is borne under change. Rather than deriving obligations or recommending action, the analysis focuses on the structural conditions under which ethical coherence persists, degrades, or collapses.

PortusEthica™ introduces a minimal triadic orientation—Conservation, Adaptation, and Environment—to describe how relations retain continuity, transform under constraint, and remain conditioned by surrounding conditions. Within this framing, ethics is understood as the legitimacy of cost placement across relations, whether cost is placed deliberately or passively through ignorance, limited capacity, or environmental pressure.

A central claim is that change is not merely additive. Under constraint, change alters the conditions of subsequent change, potentially reshaping or foreclosing future coherence. Ethical collapse is therefore treated as the loss of coherent relational form without erasure of consequence: cost persists even when the structures that once organized its placement no longer exist.

The paper deliberately refrains from grounding ethics in reason, cognition, or moral theory. No is–ought bridge is asserted, and no normative remedies are proposed. An illustrative, non-exhaustive example is included solely to demonstrate recognizability, not justification.

Attributional Preconditions (Orientation)

Ethical coherence is not available prior to attribution. While cost may arise, persist, and propagate within relational fields, ethics concerns the legitimacy of cost placement rather than its mere existence. Such legitimacy requires that cost be attributable, not only borne or distributed. For this reason, ethics is not derivable from awareness or consciousness alone; it presupposes the attributional condition established by identity. Where attribution is absent, ethical evaluation collapses into either physical consequence or external authority, neither of which constitutes ethics as described here.

1. Introduction

Ethical discourse is frequently framed in terms of values, intentions, norms, or outcomes, with ethical failure attributed to individual error, moral deficiency, or institutional misconduct. Within such framings, change is commonly treated as a sequence of events to which agents or systems respond through correction, reform, or improved decision-making. While these approaches capture important aspects of ethical life, they often obscure a more fundamental condition: ethical coherence may degrade or collapse even in the absence of malice, error, or contested values.

2. Ethics as a Pre-Anthropological Structure

Ethics is commonly treated as a human-centered domain, grounded in values, intentions, cultural norms, or systems of reasoning. Within such accounts, ethical meaning is presumed to arise only once agents capable of deliberation, communication, or shared norms are present. PortusEthica™ adopts a different starting point. Ethics is treated here as a pre-anthropological structure: a relational condition that exists prior to, and independently of, human cognition, culture, or moral discourse.

In this framing, ethics does not originate in judgment, virtue, or obligation. It arises wherever relations bear cost under constraint. Cost is understood broadly as irreducible burden, loss, or expenditure that must be borne somewhere when relations persist, transform, or fail. The ethical dimension is not the presence of cost itself, but the manner in which cost is placed, distributed, deferred, absorbed, or displaced across relations.

Treating ethics as pre-anthropological does not deny the role of human agency, reasoning, or culture in ethical life. Rather, it situates those phenomena as downstream expressions within a broader relational field. Humans do not invent ethics; they encounter and interpret ethical conditions that are already operative within the environments they inhabit and the relations they sustain.

This perspective allows ethical coherence and ethical failure to be described without recourse to blame, intention, or moral deficiency. Ethical breakdown may occur even when agents act in good faith, adhere to established norms, or reason correctly within their available frameworks. Conversely, ethical coherence may persist in the absence of explicit moral reasoning, articulated values, or conscious deliberation.

By decoupling ethics from anthropology, PortusEthica™ makes visible forms of ethical drift that arise from structural misalignment rather than from error or transgression. It also clarifies

why ethical responsibility cannot always be reduced to individual choice, and why cost is often borne by those who neither caused nor consented to its placement. Subsequent sections build on this foundation by examining how change, constraint, and environment condition the persistence or degradation of ethical coherence.

3. Change as a Conditioning Process

Change is often described as a sequence of events unfolding over time, where each state replaces the one before it. Within such descriptions, change is treated as additive, reversible in principle, or neutral with respect to the conditions under which future change occurs. PortusEthica™ adopts a different view. Change is treated here as a conditioning process: a force that alters not only what occurs, but the conditions under which subsequent relations are possible.

Under constraint and entropy, change does not merely introduce new states; it transforms the relational configuration in which states arise. As relations shift, the distribution of cost, capacity, and constraint is reconfigured. This reconfiguration may expand, narrow, or eliminate pathways that were previously available, thereby conditioning what can follow. In this sense, change is not external to ethical coherence but constitutive of it.

Because change conditions change, ethical coherence cannot be assumed to persist across transitions. Relations that once bore cost coherently may no longer do so after conditions shift, even if no agent acts differently and no values are revised. Ethical drift may therefore emerge without identifiable error, and ethical collapse may occur without deliberate choice. Consequences, however, are not erased by such collapse; they remain embedded in the relations and environments that persist beyond the loss of prior form.

This account does not presume that all change is degrading, nor that coherence is always lost. Change may also reconfigure relations in ways that permit new forms of coherence or redistribute cost in previously unavailable patterns. What is rejected is the assumption that coherence, capacity, or interpretive access is preserved by default. Whether ethical coherence persists, degrades, or terminates is contingent on how change conditions the relational state.

By treating change as a conditioning process, PortusEthica™ provides a basis for understanding ethical phenomena that resist resolution through improved decision-making alone. The persistence of ethical responsibility cannot be separated from the conditions that shape what relations can bear, perceive, or sustain. The sections that follow examine how these conditioned relations are oriented through conservation, adaptation, and environment, forming the minimal structure required to describe ethical coherence under constraint.

4. The Ethical Triad

The preceding sections have treated ethics as a pre-anthropological relational condition shaped by change, constraint, and the placement of cost. To orient this analysis without collapsing it into prescription or exhaustive structure, PortusEthica™ employs a minimal triadic framing. The triad—Conservation, Adaptation, and Environment—is introduced here as an orienting structure rather than a closed system or normative model.

The elements of the triad are not independent domains, stages, or priorities. Each is intelligible only in relation to the others, and none is presumed to be sufficient on its own to sustain ethical coherence. Together, they describe the conditions under which relations may continue to bear cost coherently, become strained, or fail under change. The triad does not assume balance, equilibrium, or recoverability, nor does it imply that coherence is always preserved.

This framing is intentionally non-exhaustive. It does not attempt to enumerate all possible ethical failure modes, nor does it resolve questions of agency, responsibility, or remedy. Instead, it provides a stable descriptive orientation for examining how ethical coherence is shaped by what is conserved, how relations adapt under constraint, and the environments within which such relations persist.

The subsections that follow examine each element of the triad in turn. They are presented sequentially for clarity, not hierarchy, and should be understood as mutually conditioning aspects of a single relational structure rather than as discrete components.

4.1 Conservation

Within PortusEthica™, conservation refers to the retention of relational coherence under constraint. It is not synonymous with preservation, stasis, or resistance to change. Rather, conservation describes the conditions under which relations continue to bear cost without loss of integrity as circumstances shift.

Conservation operates wherever continuity is required for relations to remain intelligible or viable. What is conserved may include patterns of interaction, distributions of responsibility, trust, or other relational configurations that allow cost to be absorbed rather than displaced. Importantly, conservation does not imply that forms remain unchanged; it concerns the maintenance of coherence, not the persistence of particular structures.

Ethical coherence depends on conservation insofar as relations must retain sufficient continuity to carry consequence forward. When conservation fails, relations may fragment or dissolve, and the ability to trace responsibility or consequence across change may be lost. Such failure does not erase cost already incurred; it alters where that cost is borne and whether it remains

legible within the surviving relations.

Conservation is therefore neither inherently virtuous nor inherently conservative in a political or cultural sense. Excessive conservation may impede necessary adaptation, while insufficient conservation may precipitate collapse. PortusEthica™ treats conservation descriptively, as one aspect of the conditions under which ethical coherence may persist, rather than as a directive to maintain existing forms.

In relation to adaptation and environment, conservation functions as a stabilizing constraint. It conditions how relations respond to change and whether continuity can be maintained without exceeding capacity or obscuring consequence.

4.2 Adaptation

Within PortusEthica™, adaptation refers to the transformation of relations under constraint when existing forms of conservation are no longer sufficient to maintain ethical coherence. Adaptation is not synonymous with improvement, optimization, or evolutionary progress. It describes the process by which relations alter their configuration in response to changed conditions, whether or not such transformation preserves prior values, functions, or identities.

Adaptation becomes salient when change conditions change in ways that exceed the capacity of conserved relations. In such circumstances, coherence may only be sustained through reconfiguration, redistribution of cost, or the emergence of new relational patterns. These transformations may preserve ethical coherence, degrade it, or reconstitute it in unfamiliar forms. No outcome is presumed preferable or stable by default.

Importantly, adaptation does not guarantee viability. Transformations undertaken in response to constraint may reduce future capacity, obscure the placement of cost, or introduce asymmetries that were not previously present. Adaptation may therefore coexist with ethical drift, even as relations continue to function or persist. The mere fact of continued operation does not imply sustained coherence.

Adaptation is also not inherently agent-driven. While agents may participate in adaptive processes, adaptation frequently occurs through structural reorganization, environmental pressure, or cumulative effects that exceed intentional control. As with conservation, PortusEthica™ treats adaptation descriptively rather than normatively, avoiding any implication that adaptation is required, desirable, or sufficient.

In relation to conservation and environment, adaptation functions as a mediating condition. It describes how relations transform when continuity cannot be maintained unchanged and how ethical coherence may be reshaped, strained, or lost as conditions evolve.

4.3 Environment

Within PortusEthica™, environment refers to the relational conditions under which conservation and adaptation are possible or constrained. Environment is not treated as a physical location, spatial container, or external backdrop. Rather, it denotes the set of conditions—material, energetic, informational, relational, or otherwise—that shape what relations can bear, perceive, or sustain.

Environment conditions ethical coherence by modulating constraint, capacity, and observability. It determines which relations are exposed to pressure, which costs become visible or obscured, and which forms of conservation or adaptation are viable. Changes in environment may therefore alter ethical coherence even when relations themselves remain unchanged in intent or structure.

Because environment operates as a conditioning boundary rather than an agent, its effects are often experienced indirectly. Ethical drift may arise not from decisions within relations, but from environmental shifts that redistribute burden, erode capacity, or limit interpretive access. In such cases, cost is placed through altered conditions rather than deliberate action.

Environment also plays a decisive role in the emergence of ignorance and capacity limits. Constraints on observability, feedback, or responsiveness may prevent relations from recognizing ethical drift as it occurs. Similarly, environmental pressures may exceed the capacity of relations to bear cost, precipitating collapse, inflation, or totalization independently of intent or awareness.

In relation to conservation and adaptation, environment functions as the conditioning field that renders both possible and finite. It neither guarantees coherence nor determines outcomes, but establishes the bounds within which ethical relations persist, transform, or fail.

5. Ethical Drift and Non-Equilibrium

Ethical coherence does not persist automatically once established. Under conditions of change, constraint, and environmental pressure, relations may gradually or abruptly depart from configurations that previously bore cost coherently. PortusEthica™ refers to this phenomenon as ethical drift. Drift is not synonymous with moral decline, error, or deviation from stated values. It describes a structural movement away from coherence that may occur even when intentions, norms, or practices remain unchanged.

Ethical drift arises most clearly in non-equilibrium conditions, where relations are subject to ongoing change without sufficient stabilization through conservation or successful

reconfiguration through adaptation. In such states, cost continues to be placed, but the pathways through which it is borne become misaligned with prior expectations, responsibilities, or capacities. Drift may therefore remain unnoticed until its consequences accumulate or manifest as failure.

Within this framework, it is useful to distinguish between active and passive placement of cost. Active placement occurs when agents deliberately choose where cost is borne within relations, whether through action, omission, or delegation. Passive placement occurs when cost is redistributed through structural conditions such as ignorance, limited capacity, or environmental change, without deliberate choice or awareness. Both forms result in real consequences, but only the former constitutes ethical action in the strict sense used here.

Ignorance and limited capacity function as passive conditions that shape ethical drift without constituting ethical failure. Lack of observability may prevent relations from recognizing misalignment as it emerges, while exceeded capacity may force cost to be displaced or externalized regardless of intent. In such cases, cost is borne by those who did not choose its placement, and responsibility cannot be straightforwardly assigned without accounting for structural constraint.

Ethical drift may culminate in more pronounced non-equilibrium outcomes, including collapse, inflation, or totalization. Collapse involves the loss of coherent relational form without erasure of consequence. Inflation involves unchecked expansion of scope, meaning, or obligation beyond constraint. Totalization involves closure that forecloses remainder, exception, or externality. These outcomes are not moral pathologies but structural failure modes that may arise when drift is unresolved or unrecognized.

By framing ethical drift in this manner, PortusEthica™ preserves a distinction between responsibility and blame while remaining attentive to the realities of constraint. Ethical coherence is shown to be contingent, fragile, and conditioned by factors that exceed individual agency.

6. Failure Modes Without Erasure of Consequence

Ethical coherence may terminate under non-equilibrium conditions in ways that do not erase consequence. When conservation and adaptation are no longer sufficient to sustain coherent relations, failure may occur without restoring equilibrium or eliminating the costs already incurred. PortusEthica™ treats such outcomes as failure modes without erasure of consequence. These modes are structural rather than moral, and they do not presuppose error, intent, or violation of articulated norms.

Two primary failure modes are distinguished here: collapse and inflation. They represent complementary directions of non-equilibrium failure arising from loss of proportional constraint. In both cases, consequence persists even as coherence is lost, though the manner of loss differs.

6.1 Collapse

Collapse refers to the loss of coherent relational form under conditions where conservation and adaptation can no longer sustain ethical coherence. When collapse occurs, the configurations that previously bore cost coherently no longer persist. Relations fragment, terminate, or dissolve, and the structures that once organized responsibility, attribution, or continuity are no longer available.

Collapse is irreversible with respect to lost form. While new relations may emerge after collapse, they do not recover the original configuration that failed. Importantly, the disappearance of relational form does not imply the disappearance of its effects. Consequences generated within collapsed relations continue to propagate through surviving relations and environments, often in displaced or obscured ways.

Collapse is not treated here as moral failure, permissibility, or absolution. It is a structural outcome of non-equilibrium in which ethical coherence can no longer be maintained. Subsequent actions may address downstream consequences, but they cannot retroactively restore the conditions under which coherence once existed.

6.2 Inflation

Inflation refers to loss of ethical coherence through expansion rather than termination. Under inflation, relations continue to function and may even appear successful, while scope, obligation, authority, or responsibility expand beyond proportional constraint. In such cases, coherence degrades not through disappearance of form, but through over-extension.

Unlike collapse, inflation preserves operational continuity. Systems, institutions, or relations may persist, grow, or accelerate while the placement of cost becomes increasingly opaque. Responsibility diffuses, capacity is exceeded gradually rather than abruptly, and correction becomes difficult precisely because no clear point of failure is visible.

Inflation is therefore a non-equilibrium failure mode in which ethical coherence dissolves without triggering collapse. Consequence persists and often accumulates, but without clear attribution or bounded responsibility. The appearance of success or continuity does not imply sustained coherence; it may instead mask progressive misalignment between capacity, constraint, and cost placement.

Both collapse and inflation terminate ethical coherence without erasing consequence. They differ in manifestation, visibility, and tempo, but arise from the same underlying condition: loss of proportional constraint under change.

7. Orientation Without Prescription

The preceding analysis has described the structural conditions under which ethical coherence emerges, degrades, or collapses. PortusEthica™ does not proceed from this description to the articulation of rules, duties, or recommended actions. Instead, it offers an orientation: a way of recognizing ethical conditions without converting description into prescription.

Orientation, in this context, refers to the capacity to discern where and how cost is being placed within relations as conditions change. It does not require consensus on values, agreement on outcomes, or shared normative commitments. Rather, it provides a means of attending to ethical structure prior to judgment, enabling awareness of drift, misalignment, or impending collapse without asserting what ought to be done.

Within this orientation, ethical agency is understood narrowly as the active placement of cost. Such placement may occur through deliberate action, restraint, or early attention to conditions that threaten coherence. This form of agency functions as preventative maintenance rather than corrective intervention.

Crucially, PortusEthica™ does not presume that active ethical orientation is always possible or sufficient. Ignorance, limited capacity, and environmental constraint may preclude effective action even when ethical drift is recognized. In such cases, orientation serves not as a remedy but as a means of distinguishing between unavoidable consequence and chosen cost placement.

By refusing prescription, this framework avoids conflating ethical understanding with authority or enforcement. Orientation without prescription preserves responsibility without compulsion.

8. Relationship to Schema Epistemics

PortusEthica™ is structurally adjacent to, but not derived from, Schema Epistemics, as defined in Dennis, James Roy, *Schema Epistemics: Knowledge as Constraint-Bearing Structure* (December 20, 2025). Schema Epistemics examines how knowledge functions as a constraint-bearing structure and how such structures persist, degrade, or collapse under changing conditions.

By contrast, PortusEthica™ addresses the conditions under which ethical coherence itself remains possible. While both frameworks attend to constraint, degradation, and irreversibility, they operate at different descriptive layers. Schema Epistemics is concerned with the stability and transmission of knowledge claims; PortusEthica™ is concerned with how cost is borne across relations regardless of whether knowledge remains coherent, shared, or accessible.

The two frameworks therefore intersect without subsuming one another. Ethical coherence may fail even when knowledge structures remain intact, and knowledge may persist within systems that have already experienced ethical collapse. Conversely, ethical coherence may be maintained locally in the absence of durable or shared epistemic structures.

This paper does not attempt to integrate Schema Epistemics formally or to apply its analytical machinery. The relationship articulated here is descriptive rather than hierarchical.

9. Illustrative Example (Non-Exhaustive)

The structural claims advanced in this paper do not rely on human experience for their validity. Nevertheless, a brief illustrative example is offered to demonstrate that the conditioning effects of change described here are already implicitly recognized in lived experience.

A commonly expressed human formulation—"If I had a chance to do it over..."—encapsulates an implicit recognition that change conditions change. The expression does not presume that the original conditions could be reinstated, nor that the same choice would remain available.

What is recognized in this formulation is not merely regret or counterfactual desire, but irreversibility. The phrase therefore functions as a retrospective acknowledgment that cost persists across change even when form, opportunity, or agency does not.

This recognition does not derive an obligation, nor does it prescribe response. It confirms, instead, that the conditioning nature of change is already embedded in ordinary understanding.

10. Scope and Limitations

This paper presents a descriptive account of ethical coherence under constraint as articulated through PortusEthica™. Its scope is intentionally limited. The analysis is not exhaustive, predictive, or prescriptive.

This analysis does not attempt to ground ethics in reason, cognition, or deliberative processes. Questions concerning the emergence, structure, or operation of reason are treated as adjacent but out of scope for the present work.

Similarly, this work does not derive normative obligations from descriptive conditions. Although the placement of cost under constraint may reasonably be understood as informing later normative interpretation, no is–ought bridge is asserted or defended.

The triadic structure presented is offered as an orienting framework rather than a closed system. It does not preclude the articulation of higher-resolution structures in later work.

11. Provenance and Authorship

This work was authored by James Roy Dennis. All conceptual claims, structural framings, interpretations, and limitations expressed herein originate with the author.

Portions of the drafting and structural refinement process were assisted by AI-based language tools used strictly as editorial and organizational aids. These tools did not originate concepts or theoretical claims.

12. Declarations and Publication Notes

Declaration of Interest. The author declares no competing interests.

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